BARBM312 · BACHELOR · FHEQ LEVEL 6 · 5 ECTS · EU BUSINESS SCHOOL

The Council of Giants

AI in Investment and Business Growth · Framework Author Library

"If I have seen further, it is by standing on the shoulders of giants."

— Sir Isaac Newton

32 thinkers · 7 units · the minds behind all 140 frameworks

32	Framework authors *one distilled profile per thinker*	**7**	Course units *a five-member panel convenes for each*
140	Frameworks anchored *every Slibrary traces to a Giant*	**6**	Profile dimensions *why · foundation · frameworks · use · limits · impact*

How to use the Council. Each profile distils one thinker in the JD Meier "Author Distilled" tradition: the why that drove their work, its intellectual foundation, the frameworks they anchor in this course, how those ideas operationalise, their limitations, and their enduring impact. The Giants are simulations of public logic, not the people themselves — an echo, not a conversation. Convene a unit's panel of five to find friction and sharper distinctions before you decide; never treat them as a substitute for your own judgment.

Dr. Hildegard Haas · EU Business School · BARBM312

PANELS

Who convenes for each unit

Each unit summons a panel of five Giants whose frameworks anchor its Slibraries. Three thinkers — Boyd, Christensen and Thiel — sit on two panels. The profiles that follow are ordered by first appearance.

Unit 1 · AI, Data & Strategic Business Growth — *Guided Discovery*

- RA Russell Ackoff
- JB John Boyd
- CC Clayton Christensen
- JC Jan Carlzon
- WC W. Chan Kim & R. Mauborgne

Unit 2 · The Economics of AI Adoption — Benefits — *Live Data Lab*

- EB Erik Brynjolfsson
- RS Robert Solow
- ER Everett Rogers
- EG Eliyahu Goldratt
- DM Dave McClure

Unit 3 · The Economics of AI Adoption — Costs — *Mini-Hackathon*

- NN Nassim Nicholas Taleb
- CO Cathy O'Neil
- AN Andrew Ng
- RS Roy Schwartz et al.
- JQ J.B. Quinn

Unit 4 · IP & Value Creation through AI — *Moot Court*

- JL Jyh-An Lee et al.
- HH Hamilton Helmer
- PT Peter Thiel
- LL Lawrence Lessig
- AH Andrei Hagiu & Julian Wright

Unit 5 · Agility, Disruption & Rebranding in the Age of AI — *Role Play*

- JB John Boyd
- CC Clayton Christensen
- DS Dave Snowden
- JK John Kotter
- DM Donald Miller

Unit 6 · Investment Strategies in the AI Era — *Live Data Lab*

- HM Harry Markowitz
- FB Fischer Black & Robert Litterman
- EF Eugene Fama & Kenneth French
- ML Marcos López de Prado
- AG Agrawal, Gans & Goldfarb

Unit 7 · Innovative AI Enterprises — From Unicorns to Industry Leaders — *Business Challenge · Capstone*

- PT Peter Thiel
- RH Reid Hoffman
- GM Geoffrey Moore
- SC Sangeet Choudary
- SB Sara Blakely

RA Russell Ackoff

Systems thinker · operations research · the DIKW hierarchy

GIANT 01 / 32
Unit 1

1919–2009 · American organisational theorist and pioneer of systems thinking.

> *"A wealth of data creates a poverty of attention."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Ackoff was preoccupied with why organisations, awash in data, so rarely act wisely. He insisted that information is not understanding and that most management problems are 'messes' — systems of interacting problems that cannot be solved piecemeal.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Trained in architecture and philosophy of science, Ackoff helped found the field of operations research before turning against its narrow optimisation. His systems philosophy held that a system's behaviour depends on how its parts interact, not on the parts in isolation.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

In BARBM312 he anchors the DIKW Pyramid (Data → Information → Knowledge → Wisdom), the lens through which Unit 1 treats data as valuable only when it climbs toward judgment and action.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His ideas operationalise as a discipline of asking what decision a piece of data is meant to inform, and refusing to mistake accumulation of data for understanding.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Critics note the DIKW hierarchy is more a useful heuristic than a rigorous theory, and that the boundaries between its levels are contested. Ackoff himself warned against treating his models as formulae.

ENDURING IMPACT

DIKW remains a foundational idea across information science, knowledge management and analytics, and his systems thinking shaped a generation of management theory.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 1)

John Boyd · Giant 2 | **Clayton Christensen** · Giant 3 | **Jan Carlzon** · Giant 4 | **W. Chan Kim & R. Mauborgne** · Giant 5

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Ackoff, R.L. (1989) 'From data to wisdom', Journal of Applied Systems Analysis, 16, pp. 3–9.
Ackoff, R.L. (1999) Ackoff's Best. New York: Wiley.

JB

John Boyd

Military strategist · the OODA loop · manoeuvre and tempo

GIANT 02 / 32
Units 1 & 5

1927–1997 · United States Air Force colonel and strategist.

> *"Whoever can handle the quickest rate of change survives."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Boyd wanted to know why a force that was slower or smaller could still win. His answer was tempo: the side that observes, orients, decides and acts faster forces its opponent to react to a world that has already changed.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

A fighter pilot and aeronautical engineer, Boyd developed energy–manoeuvrability theory and then a broader theory of conflict. He never wrote a book; his ideas live in briefings such as 'Patterns of Conflict' and 'A Discourse on Winning and Losing'.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the OODA Loop, central to Unit 1's decision-intelligence theme and Unit 5's treatment of business agility as the speed of organisational re-decision.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

OODA operationalises as a continuous cycle in which the orientation step — shaped by experience and mental models — is decisive, and tempo is treated as a weapon.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

OODA is sometimes reduced to a simplistic 'go faster' slogan, losing Boyd's emphasis on orientation and on disrupting the opponent's cycle. Its empirical generality beyond aerial combat is debated.

ENDURING IMPACT

OODA has migrated from the cockpit into business strategy, cybersecurity, agile practice and litigation, becoming a default model of adaptive decision-making.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 1)

- **Russell Ackoff** · Giant 1
- **Clayton Christensen** · Giant 3
- **Jan Carlzon** · Giant 4
- **W. Chan Kim & R. Mauborgne** · Giant 5

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Boyd, J. (1986) 'Patterns of Conflict' (briefing).

Osinga, F. (2007) Science, Strategy and War: The Strategic Theory of John Boyd. London: Routledge.

CC

Clayton Christensen

Innovation scholar · disruptive innovation · Jobs To Be Done

GIANT 03 / 32
Units 1 & 5

1952–2020 · Harvard Business School professor.

> *"Customers hire products to do a job."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Christensen sought to explain a paradox: why great, well-managed companies fail. His answer was that the very practices that make incumbents successful — listening to their best customers — blind them to disruptive entrants rising from below.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Drawing on detailed industry histories (notably disk drives), Christensen built a theory distinguishing sustaining from disruptive innovation, later complemented by his causal theory of demand, Jobs To Be Done.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors Jobs To Be Done (Unit 1) and the Innovator's Dilemma and Disruption S-Curves (Unit 5), framing both how customers 'hire' products and how incumbents lose to disruptors.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His theories operationalise as a discipline of watching low-end and new-market footholds, and of designing around the customer's job rather than the product's features.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Scholars have questioned the predictive power and selective cases of disruption theory; Christensen acknowledged it is often misapplied to any new competitor rather than true disruptors.

ENDURING IMPACT

Disruptive innovation became one of the most influential — and most cited — ideas in modern management, reshaping how incumbents think about threats.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 1)

Russell Ackoff · Giant 1 | **John Boyd** · Giant 2 | **Jan Carlzon** · Giant 4 | **W. Chan Kim & R. Mauborgne** · Giant 5

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Christensen, C.M. (1997) The Innovator's Dilemma. Boston: HBS Press.

Christensen, C.M. et al. (2016) Competing Against Luck. New York: HarperBusiness.

Jan Carlzon

JC

Service-management leader · Moments of Truth

GIANT 04 / 32
Unit 1

b. 1941 · Swedish businessman, former CEO of Scandinavian Airlines (SAS).

> *"15 seconds decides the whole relationship."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Carlzon believed that a service business is built or destroyed in the brief frontline encounters customers actually remember, not in the boardroom or the org chart.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

As CEO of a struggling SAS in the early 1980s, he reoriented the airline around the customer-facing 'moments of truth', decentralising authority to frontline staff.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors Moments of Truth in Unit 1, the lens that concentrates customer-experience investment on the decisive few interactions.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His approach operationalises as empowering frontline employees to act in the customer's interest at the moment of contact, supported rather than constrained by management.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The idea can underweight the back-stage systems and culture that make good frontline moments possible; moments of truth are necessary but not sufficient.

ENDURING IMPACT

'Moments of truth' entered the standard vocabulary of service management and customer experience, later extended by Procter & Gamble and Google.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 1)

Russell Ackoff · Giant 1 | **John Boyd** · Giant 2 | **Clayton Christensen** · Giant 3 | **W. Chan Kim & R. Mauborgne** · Giant 5

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Carlzon, J. (1987) Moments of Truth. Cambridge: Ballinger.

Normann, R. (1984) Service Management. Chichester: Wiley.

W. Chan Kim & R. Mauborgne

WC

Strategy scholars · Blue Ocean Strategy · value innovation

Contemporary · professors at INSEAD.

> *"Make the competition irrelevant."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Kim and Mauborgne asked why firms exhaust themselves competing in crowded 'red oceans' when they could create uncontested market space instead.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Their research across many industries argued that lasting success comes from value innovation — simultaneously raising buyer value and lowering cost — rather than from beating rivals on the same terms.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

They anchor the Blue Ocean Strategy Canvas in Unit 1's opportunity-sensing Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Blue Ocean operationalises through tools such as the strategy canvas and the eliminate-reduce-raise-create grid, redrawing an industry's value curve.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Critics note blue oceans can be hard to identify in advance and are quickly contested once proven; the theory is stronger as a lens than as a repeatable formula.

ENDURING IMPACT

Blue Ocean Strategy became a global bestseller and a standard part of the strategy canon, popularising value innovation and market creation.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 1)

Russell Ackoff · Giant 1 | **John Boyd** · Giant 2 | **Clayton Christensen** · Giant 3 | **Jan Carlzon** · Giant 4

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Kim, W.C. and Mauborgne, R. (2005) Blue Ocean Strategy. Boston: HBS Press.

Kim, W.C. and Mauborgne, R. (2017) Blue Ocean Shift. New York: Hachette.

EB

Erik Brynjolfsson

Economist of technology · the productivity J-curve

Contemporary · director of the Stanford Digital Economy Lab.

> *"The benefits lag the investment by years."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Brynjolfsson has spent his career on a single puzzle: why transformative technologies often fail to show up in productivity statistics for years before delivering large gains.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

His empirical work on IT and, later, AI established that realising value requires heavy investment in complementary intangibles — skills, processes, data and organisational change.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Productivity J-Curve and informs the Intangible Capital Iceberg in Unit 2's treatment of AI benefits.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His ideas operationalise as patience with the J-curve dip and deliberate investment in the intangible complements that create the eventual payoff.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The J-curve is harder to apply in real time than in retrospect, and distinguishing a genuine lag from a genuine absence of value remains a judgment call.

ENDURING IMPACT

Brynjolfsson is among the most influential economists of the digital and AI economy, shaping how firms and policymakers interpret AI's economic impact.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 2)

Robert Solow · Giant 7 | **Everett Rogers** · Giant 8 | **Eliyahu Goldratt** · Giant 9 | **Dave McClure** · Giant 10

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Brynjolfsson, E., Rock, D. and Syverson, C. (2021) 'The Productivity J-Curve', AEJ: Macro, 13(1).

Brynjolfsson, E. and McAfee, A. (2014) The Second Machine Age. New York: Norton.

RS

Robert Solow

Nobel economist · growth theory · the productivity paradox

GIANT 07 / 32
Unit 2

1924–2023 · MIT economist, Nobel laureate (1987).

> *"Computers everywhere except the productivity statistics."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Solow's growth theory sought to explain what drives long-run economic growth, concluding that technological progress — not just capital — is the main engine.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

His neoclassical growth model earned the Nobel Prize; his 1987 quip that the computer age was visible 'everywhere except in the productivity statistics' named the productivity paradox.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Solow Paradox Revisited in Unit 2, the caution that visible technology adoption does not guarantee measured productivity gains.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His paradox operationalises as a discipline of looking for lags, mismeasurement and missing complements before concluding a technology has failed.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The paradox describes a puzzle more than it prescribes a remedy; its resolution depends on later work on lags and intangibles.

ENDURING IMPACT

Solow's growth theory founded modern growth economics, and the paradox remains the reference point for every debate about technology and productivity.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 2)

Erik Brynjolfsson · Giant 6 | **Everett Rogers** · Giant 8 | **Eliyahu Goldratt** · Giant 9 | **Dave McClure** · Giant 10

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Solow, R. (1956) 'A contribution to the theory of economic growth', Quarterly Journal of Economics, 70(1).
Solow, R. (1987) 'We'd better watch out', New York Times Book Review.

ER

Everett Rogers

Communication scholar · Diffusion of Innovations

GIANT 08 / 32
Unit 2

1931–2004 · American sociologist and communication theorist.

> *"Adoption is a social process, not a switch."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Rogers asked why some innovations spread rapidly while others, equally good, fail — and concluded that adoption is a social process, not a technical inevitability.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Synthesising hundreds of studies, he built a general theory of how innovations diffuse through a population over time, defining adopter categories from innovators to laggards.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Diffusion S-Curve in Unit 2, the model of how AI and other innovations are adopted in stages.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His theory operationalises as tailoring strategy to the next adopter group and attending to an innovation's perceived attributes (relative advantage, compatibility, complexity, trialability, observability).

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The model can underweight power, inequality and the active shaping of diffusion by firms, and adopter categories are idealised.

ENDURING IMPACT

Diffusion of Innovations is among the most cited works in the social sciences, underpinning marketing, public health and technology strategy.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 2)

Erik Brynjolfsson · Giant 6 | **Robert Solow** · Giant 7 | **Eliyahu Goldratt** · Giant 9 | **Dave McClure** · Giant 10

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Rogers, E.M. (1962) Diffusion of Innovations. New York: Free Press.

Rogers, E.M. (2003) Diffusion of Innovations. 5th edn. New York: Free Press.

Eliyahu Goldratt

Physicist-turned-management thinker · Theory of Constraints

GIANT 09 / 32
Unit 2

EG

1947–2011 · Israeli physicist and business consultant.

> *"An hour saved off a non-bottleneck is a mirage."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Goldratt argued that every system has a single binding constraint, and that improving anything other than the constraint is an illusion of progress.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

His Theory of Constraints, dramatised in the business novel The Goal, reframed operations around identifying and exploiting the bottleneck that governs throughput.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors Throughput Accounting in Unit 2's productivity-gains Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His method operationalises as the five focusing steps: identify, exploit, subordinate, elevate and then repeat at the next constraint.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The single-constraint assumption can oversimplify systems with multiple interacting bottlenecks, and throughput accounting sits uneasily beside conventional cost accounting.

ENDURING IMPACT

The Theory of Constraints reshaped operations management and project management, and The Goal remains a widely taught business text.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 2)

Erik Brynjolfsson · Giant 6 | **Robert Solow** · Giant 7 | **Everett Rogers** · Giant 8 | **Dave McClure** · Giant 10

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Goldratt, E.M. (1984) The Goal. Great Barrington: North River Press.

Goldratt, E.M. (1990) Theory of Constraints. Great Barrington: North River Press.

DM

Dave McClure

Investor and entrepreneur · Pirate Metrics (AARRR)

Contemporary · venture investor, founder of 500 Startups.

> *"Measure the funnel, not the vanity."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

McClure wanted startups to stop chasing vanity metrics and focus on the few numbers that actually drive a business.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

From a background in software and early-stage investing, he distilled startup measurement into five actionable stages.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors Pirate Metrics (AARRR) — Acquisition, Activation, Retention, Referral, Revenue — in Unit 2's revenue-and-customer Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

AARRR operationalises as measuring each stage of the customer funnel and concentrating experimentation on the weakest link.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

As a startup heuristic it can oversimplify complex businesses and underweight retention dynamics that later loop-based models emphasise.

ENDURING IMPACT

AARRR became a default framework in growth and product analytics, widely taught and applied across the startup world.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 2)

Erik Brynjolfsson · Giant 6 | **Robert Solow** · Giant 7 | **Everett Rogers** · Giant 8 | **Eliyahu Goldratt** · Giant 9

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

McClure, D. (2007) 'Startup metrics for pirates', 500 Startups.

Croll, A. and Yoskovitz, B. (2013) Lean Analytics. Sebastopol: O'Reilly.

NN

Nassim Nicholas Taleb

Scholar of uncertainty · Black Swan · antifragility

b. 1960 · Lebanese-American essayist, statistician and former trader.

> *"It is the rare event that ruins you."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Taleb is concerned with the rare, high-impact event that conventional models ignore — and with building systems that survive, even benefit from, such shocks.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Drawing on trading, probability and philosophy, he attacked naïve reliance on the normal distribution and on prediction, arguing that fragility to tail events is the central risk.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Black Swan Radar in Unit 3's risk-and-trade-off Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His thinking operationalises as a preference for robustness and optionality over precise forecasting, and as relentless attention to downside tail risk.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Critics find his arguments combative and sometimes unfalsifiable, and note that 'avoid fragility' is easier to state than to implement.

ENDURING IMPACT

The Black Swan reshaped popular and professional thinking about risk after the 2008 crisis, and 'black swan' entered everyday language.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 3)

Cathy O'Neil · Giant 12 | **Andrew Ng** · Giant 13 | **Roy Schwartz et al.** · Giant 14 | **J.B. Quinn** · Giant 15

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Taleb, N.N. (2007) The Black Swan. London: Penguin.

Taleb, N.N. (2012) Antifragile. New York: Random House.

Cathy O'Neil

Mathematician and data scientist · algorithmic accountability

b. 1972 · American mathematician and author.

> *"Models are opinions embedded in maths."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

O'Neil warns that opaque algorithms, deployed at scale, can entrench bias and harm while hiding behind a veneer of mathematical objectivity.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

A mathematics PhD who worked in finance and data science, she turned to exposing the social harms of poorly governed models, coining the idea of 'weapons of math destruction'.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

She anchors the Bias & Failure Modes Map in Unit 3's risk Slibrary and informs responsible-AI thinking throughout the course.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Her work operationalises as auditing models for fairness, transparency and harm, and treating bias as a design and governance concern.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Her critique is sharper at diagnosis than prescription; operationalising algorithmic fairness remains technically and ethically contested.

ENDURING IMPACT

She helped launch the public conversation on algorithmic accountability that now shapes AI regulation and responsible-AI practice.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 3)

Nassim Nicholas Taleb · Giant 11 | **Andrew Ng** · Giant 13 | **Roy Schwartz et al.** · Giant 14 | **J.B. Quinn** · Giant 15

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

O'Neil, C. (2016) Weapons of Math Destruction. New York: Crown.

Mehrabi, N. et al. (2021) 'A survey on bias and fairness in machine learning', ACM Computing Surveys, 54(6).

Andrew Ng

AI researcher and educator · data-centric AI and MLOps

b. 1976 · British-American computer scientist; co-founder of Google Brain and Coursera.

> *"It's not the model, it's the data and the plumbing."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Ng argues that, for most organisations, the bottleneck to AI value is not the model but the data and the engineering around it.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

A leading machine-learning researcher and educator, he led large-scale AI efforts at Google and Baidu and championed the shift from model-centric to data-centric AI.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the MLOps Maturity Ladder in Unit 3's model-and-talent Slibrary and informs its treatment of operational cost.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His view operationalises as investing in data quality, reliable pipelines and disciplined MLOps rather than chasing marginal model gains.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The data-centric emphasis can understate cases where model architecture genuinely matters, and 'good data' is itself hard to define and obtain.

ENDURING IMPACT

Ng has shaped both AI research and its practical adoption, and through online education brought machine learning to millions.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 3)

Nassim Nicholas Taleb · Giant 11 | **Cathy O'Neil** · Giant 12 | **Roy Schwartz et al.** · Giant 14 | **J.B. Quinn** · Giant 15

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Ng, A. (2021) 'A chat with Andrew on MLOps: From model-centric to data-centric AI', DeepLearning.AI.

Kreuzberger, D., Kühl, N. and Hirschl, S. (2023) 'Machine learning operations (MLOps)', IEEE Access, 11.

RS

Roy Schwartz et al.

AI researchers · Green AI and the cost of computation

Contemporary · researchers including Roy Schwartz, Jesse Dodge, Noah Smith and Oren Etzioni.

> *"Efficiency must be a first-class metric."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

They argue that the AI field's pursuit of accuracy at any computational cost — 'Red AI' — is unsustainable, and that efficiency should be a first-class research and business value.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Their work documented the rising compute and carbon cost of state-of-the-art models and proposed efficiency as an explicit goal alongside accuracy.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

They anchor the Green AI vs. Red AI perspective informing Unit 3's cost, risk and sustainability Slibraries.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Their proposal operationalises as reporting and optimising the computational and environmental cost of models, not only their accuracy.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Efficiency metrics are still inconsistently reported, and the trade-off between capability and cost is contested as models scale.

ENDURING IMPACT

'Green AI' helped put the energy and cost footprint of AI on the research and corporate agenda, influencing sustainable-AI practice.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 3)

Nassim Nicholas Taleb · Giant 11 | **Cathy O'Neil** · Giant 12 | **Andrew Ng** · Giant 13 | **J.B. Quinn** · Giant 15

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Schwartz, R., Dodge, J., Smith, N.A. and Etzioni, O. (2020) 'Green AI', Communications of the ACM, 63(12).

Patterson, D. et al. (2021) 'Carbon emissions and large neural network training', arXiv:2104.10350.

JQ

J.B. Quinn

Strategy scholar · strategic outsourcing and core competence

GIANT 15 / 32
Unit 3

1928–2012 · James Brian Quinn, professor at Dartmouth's Tuck School.

> *"Own the core, rent the rest."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Quinn argued that firms should concentrate on the few activities where they can be best in the world and strategically outsource the rest.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

His work on logical incrementalism and on intelligent enterprise reframed strategy around core competencies, knowledge and selective outsourcing.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the strategic-outsourcing reasoning behind Unit 3's make-versus-buy and sourcing Slibraries.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His ideas operationalise as the principle 'own the core, rent the rest' — retaining strategically vital capabilities and outsourcing the rest.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Aggressive outsourcing can hollow out capability and create dependency, a risk Quinn acknowledged but that firms often underestimate.

ENDURING IMPACT

Quinn's work shaped the outsourcing and core-competence movements that define modern corporate strategy and sourcing decisions.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 3)

Nassim Nicholas Taleb · Giant 11 | **Cathy O'Neil** · Giant 12 | **Andrew Ng** · Giant 13 | **Roy Schwartz et al.** · Giant 14

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Quinn, J.B. (1992) Intelligent Enterprise. New York: Free Press.

Quinn, J.B. and Hilmer, F.G. (1994) 'Strategic outsourcing', Sloan Management Review, 35(4).

JL Jyh-An Lee et al.

Legal scholars · AI, authorship and intellectual property

GIANT 16 / 32
Unit 4

Contemporary · editors including Jyh-An Lee, Reto Hilty and Kung-Chung Liu.

> *"Authorship requires a human spark."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

They confront the question of whether, and how, intellectual-property law can accommodate creations made with or by artificial intelligence.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Their edited scholarship surveys how copyright, patent and related regimes handle AI authorship and inventorship across jurisdictions.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

They anchor the Authorship Decision Tree in Unit 4's IP Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Their analysis operationalises as a structured way to classify AI-assisted outputs by the human contribution and to anticipate their protectability.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The law is unsettled and varies by jurisdiction; any decision tree is provisional pending legislation and case law.

ENDURING IMPACT

Their work is a key reference as courts, offices and legislators grapple with AI's challenge to intellectual-property doctrine.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 4)

Hamilton Helmer · Giant 17 | **Peter Thiel** · Giant 18 | **Lawrence Lessig** · Giant 19 | **Andrei Hagiu & Julian Wright** · Giant 20

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Lee, J.-A., Hilty, R.M. and Liu, K.-C. (eds.) (2021) Artificial Intelligence and Intellectual Property. Oxford: OUP.

Abbott, R. (2020) The Reasonable Robot. Cambridge: CUP.

Hamilton Helmer

HH

Strategist and investor · 7 Powers

GIANT 17 / 32
Unit 4

Contemporary · strategy consultant and investor.

> *"Power is the potential to earn persistent returns."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Helmer set out to define precisely what creates durable competitive advantage — the 'power' to earn persistent differential returns.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Drawing on decades of strategy practice and investing, he distilled durable advantage into seven distinct, exhaustive sources.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors 7 Powers and informs the Defensibility Matrix and Wrapper-vs-Moat Ladder in Unit 4.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

7 Powers operationalises as testing a business for each specific power rather than invoking a vague 'moat'.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Identifying and building a power is harder in practice than classifying one, and the framework is descriptive rather than predictive.

ENDURING IMPACT

7 Powers has become a widely used strategy reference among founders and investors for analysing defensibility.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 4)

Jyh-An Lee et al. · Giant 16
Peter Thiel · Giant 18
Lawrence Lessig · Giant 19
Andrei Hagiu & Julian Wright · Giant 20

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Helmer, H. (2016) 7 Powers: The Foundations of Business Strategy. Deep Strategy.
Porter, M.E. (1980) Competitive Strategy. New York: Free Press.

PT

Peter Thiel

Entrepreneur and investor · monopoly and differentiation

GIANT 18 / 32
Units 4 & 7

b. 1967 · co-founder of PayPal and Palantir, venture investor.

> *"Is your product better — or different?"*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Thiel argues that competition is overrated and that durable value comes from building something so different it amounts to a monopoly.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

From founding PayPal and early investing in technology companies, he developed a contrarian theory of startups built around escaping competition.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the differentiation-and-monopoly reasoning in Unit 4 (moat versus wrapper) and the zero-to-one logic in Unit 7's scaling Slibraries.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His thinking operationalises as the question 'is your product better, or different?' and the pursuit of a defensible niche to dominate.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

His celebration of monopoly is controversial on competition and policy grounds, and 'be different' is more provocation than method.

ENDURING IMPACT

Zero to One became a defining text of startup strategy, popularising the pursuit of differentiation over imitation.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 4)

Jyh-An Lee et al. · Giant 16

Hamilton Helmer · Giant 17

Lawrence Lessig · Giant 19

Andrei Hagiu & Julian Wright · Giant 20

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Thiel, P. (2014) Zero to One. New York: Crown Business.

Thiel, P. (2014) 'Competition is for losers', Wall Street Journal.

LL

Lawrence Lessig

Legal scholar · code, law and licensing

b. 1961 · Harvard Law professor; founder of Creative Commons.

> *"Code is law; licences are choices."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Lessig argues that in a digital world 'code is law' — software architecture regulates behaviour as powerfully as legal rules — and that licensing is therefore a design choice with public consequences.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

A constitutional and cyberlaw scholar, he founded Creative Commons to give creators flexible alternatives to default copyright.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the licensing reasoning behind Unit 4's Licensing Models Map and Open-Source Compliance Ladder.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His ideas operationalise as treating licence choice as a deliberate strategic and ethical decision, especially where AI code inherits training-data obligations.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The 'code is law' thesis can understate the continuing force of formal law and markets, and licensing alone cannot resolve AI's IP questions.

ENDURING IMPACT

Lessig shaped digital-rights and open-licensing movements; Creative Commons licences are used across millions of works.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 4)

Jyh-An Lee et al. · Giant 16 | **Hamilton Helmer** · Giant 17 | **Peter Thiel** · Giant 18 | **Andrei Hagiu & Julian Wright** · Giant 20

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Lessig, L. (1999) Code and Other Laws of Cyberspace. New York: Basic Books.

Lessig, L. (2004) Free Culture. New York: Penguin.

Andrei Hagiu & Julian Wright

Economists of platforms and data · data network effects

Contemporary · academic economists of platform strategy.

> *"Data advantage must compound to matter."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Hagiu and Wright examine when data genuinely creates competitive advantage — and caution that, contrary to popular belief, more data does not automatically compound into a moat.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Their research on multi-sided platforms and data-enabled learning distinguishes the conditions under which data improves a product and is hard to replicate.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

They anchor Data Network Effects and inform the Proprietary Data Flywheel and Data Moat Strength in Units 1 and 4.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Their analysis operationalises as testing whether additional data measurably improves the product and whether that improvement is defensible.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The conditions for genuine data advantage are stringent and context-specific, making general prescriptions difficult.

ENDURING IMPACT

Their work brought rigour to the loose claim of 'data moats', shaping how investors and strategists assess data-based advantage.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 4)

Jyh-An Lee et al. · Giant 16 | **Hamilton Helmer** · Giant 17 | **Peter Thiel** · Giant 18 | **Lawrence Lessig** · Giant 19

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Hagiu, A. and Wright, J. (2020) 'When data creates competitive advantage', Harvard Business Review, 98(1).
Hagiu, A. and Wright, J. (2023) 'Data-enabled learning, network effects, and competitive advantage', RAND Journal of Economics, 54(4).

DS

Dave Snowden

Knowledge and complexity scholar · the Cynefin framework

b. 1954 · Welsh management consultant and researcher.

> *"Match the response to the kind of problem."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Snowden argues that leaders fail when they apply the same management approach to fundamentally different kinds of problem, and that complex situations demand probing and adaptation, not rigid planning.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Developed while at IBM, his Cynefin framework draws on complexity science and knowledge management to distinguish ordered from unordered domains.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Cynefin Framework in Unit 5's business-agility Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Cynefin operationalises as diagnosing a situation's domain and matching the response — best practice, expertise, safe-to-fail experiments, or rapid action.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Domain boundaries can be ambiguous in practice, and the framework is a sense-making aid rather than a predictive model.

ENDURING IMPACT

Cynefin is widely used in management, software and public policy as a tool for navigating complexity and uncertainty.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 5)

John Boyd · Giant 2 | **Clayton Christensen** · Giant 3 | **John Kotter** · Giant 22 | **Donald Miller** · Giant 23

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Snowden, D.J. and Boone, M.E. (2007) 'A leader's framework for decision making', Harvard Business Review, 85(11).

Kurtz, C.F. and Snowden, D.J. (2003) 'The new dynamics of strategy', IBM Systems Journal, 42(3).

JK

John Kotter

Leadership scholar · leading organisational change

GIANT 22 / 32
Unit 5

b. 1947 · Harvard Business School professor emeritus.

> *"Most change efforts fail for lack of urgency."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Kotter sought to explain why most change efforts fail and what distinguishes the few that succeed, concluding that change is led, not merely managed.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

From extensive study of corporate change programmes, he distilled a recurring pattern of failure and a corresponding eight-step process for success.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors Kotter's 8 Steps in Unit 5's change-as-a-motor Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His process operationalises as a sequence beginning with urgency and a guiding coalition and ending with anchoring change in the culture.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The linear eight-step model can feel rigid for continuous or emergent change, and urgency can be manufactured cynically.

ENDURING IMPACT

Kotter's work is among the most widely used change-management frameworks in business and the public sector.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 5)

John Boyd · Giant 2 | **Clayton Christensen** · Giant 3 | **Dave Snowden** · Giant 21 | **Donald Miller** · Giant 23

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Kotter, J.P. (1996) Leading Change. Boston: HBS Press.

Kotter, J.P. (1995) 'Leading change: Why transformation efforts fail', Harvard Business Review, 73(2).

DM

Donald Miller

Marketing author · StoryBrand and narrative messaging

GIANT 23 / 32
Unit 5

Contemporary · author and founder of the StoryBrand framework.

> *"The customer is the hero, not the brand."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Miller argues that brands lose customers through unclear messaging, and that clarity comes from casting the customer — not the brand — as the hero of the story.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Drawing on classic narrative structure, he built a seven-part messaging framework that positions the brand as the guide who helps the customer-hero succeed.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the StoryBrand Framework in Unit 5's strategic-rebranding Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

StoryBrand operationalises as rewriting messaging so the customer is the hero, the brand is the guide, and a clear plan leads to success.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The formula can feel templated and is more a communication discipline than a complete brand strategy.

ENDURING IMPACT

StoryBrand became a widely adopted marketing methodology, especially among small and mid-sized businesses.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 5)

John Boyd · Giant 2 | **Clayton Christensen** · Giant 3 | **Dave Snowden** · Giant 21 | **John Kotter** · Giant 22

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Miller, D. (2017) Building a StoryBrand. Nashville: HarperCollins Leadership.
Campbell, J. (1949) The Hero with a Thousand Faces. New York: Pantheon.

HM

Harry Markowitz

Nobel economist · Modern Portfolio Theory

1927–2023 · American economist, Nobel laureate (1990).

> *"Diversification is the only free lunch."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Markowitz asked how an investor should construct a portfolio given that returns are uncertain, and showed that risk depends on how assets move together, not just on each asset alone.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

His 1952 paper formalised diversification mathematically, defining the efficient frontier of portfolios offering the best return for a given risk.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors Modern Portfolio Theory and informs the Diversification Curve in Unit 6's investment-foundations Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

MPT operationalises as combining imperfectly correlated assets to minimise variance for a target return.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

MPT relies on estimates of returns, variances and correlations that are noisy and unstable, motivating later refinements such as Black-Litterman.

ENDURING IMPACT

Markowitz founded modern quantitative finance; diversification as the 'only free lunch' remains a bedrock principle.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 6)

- **Fischer Black & Robert Litterman** · Giant 25
- **Eugene Fama & Kenneth French** · Giant 26
- **Marcos López de Prado** · Giant 27
- **Agrawal, Gans & Goldfarb** · Giant 28

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Markowitz, H. (1952) 'Portfolio selection', The Journal of Finance, 7(1).
Markowitz, H. (1959) Portfolio Selection. New York: Wiley.

FB

Fischer Black & Robert Litterman

Financial economists · Bayesian asset allocation

GIANT 25 / 32
Unit 6

Fischer Black 1938–1995; Robert Litterman b. 1951 · developed their model at Goldman Sachs.

> *"Start from the market, then add your views."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

They sought to fix the extreme, unstable portfolios that pure mean-variance optimisation produces when fed noisy return estimates.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

At Goldman Sachs in the early 1990s, they combined market-equilibrium returns with investor views in a Bayesian framework.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

They anchor the Black-Litterman Model in Unit 6's investment-foundations Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

The model operationalises as starting from market-implied returns and tilting toward an investor's views in proportion to confidence.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

It still requires subjective inputs — views and confidence levels — and inherits the assumptions of the underlying equilibrium model.

ENDURING IMPACT

Black-Litterman became a standard tool in institutional asset allocation and a principled way to incorporate active views, including AI-generated signals.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 6)

Harry Markowitz · Giant 24

Eugene Fama & Kenneth French · Giant 26

Marcos López de Prado · Giant 27

Agrawal, Gans & Goldfarb · Giant 28

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Black, F. and Litterman, R. (1992) 'Global portfolio optimization', Financial Analysts Journal, 48(5).

He, G. and Litterman, R. (1999) 'The intuition behind Black-Litterman model portfolios', Goldman Sachs.

EF

Eugene Fama & Kenneth French

Financial economists · multi-factor asset pricing

GIANT 26 / 32
Unit 6

Eugene Fama b. 1939 (Nobel laureate, 2013); Kenneth French b. 1954 · University of Chicago and Dartmouth.

> *"Returns have more than one source."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Fama and French sought to explain patterns in stock returns that the single-factor CAPM could not, finding that size and value (and later other factors) systematically affect returns.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Building on Fama's efficient-markets work, their empirical research established that multiple factors, not market risk alone, drive returns.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

They anchor the Fama-French Factors in Unit 6's prediction-and-risk Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Their model operationalises as decomposing returns into factor exposures and building or evaluating portfolios by their factor loadings.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Factor definitions and the number of 'real' factors are debated, and some factors have weakened out of sample (the 'factor zoo' problem).

ENDURING IMPACT

Multi-factor asset pricing transformed both academic finance and the practice of factor investing and smart-beta strategies.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 6)

- **Harry Markowitz** · Giant 24
- **Fischer Black & Robert Litterman** · Giant 25
- **Marcos López de Prado** · Giant 27
- **Agrawal, Gans & Goldfarb** · Giant 28

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Fama, E.F. and French, K.R. (1993) 'Common risk factors in the returns on stocks and bonds', Journal of Financial Economics, 33(1).

Fama, E.F. and French, K.R. (2015) 'A five-factor asset pricing model', Journal of Financial Economics, 116(1).

ML Marcos López de Prado

Quantitative researcher · financial machine learning

Contemporary · quantitative investment researcher and author.

> *"Most backtests are false discoveries."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

López de Prado warns that applying machine learning naïvely to finance produces false discoveries — strategies that look brilliant in backtests and fail in reality.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

From a career in quantitative asset management, he developed methods to apply machine learning to finance rigorously and to detect overfitting.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Backtesting Pitfalls Map in Unit 6's prediction-and-risk Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His work operationalises as treating a spectacular backtest as a hypothesis to be stress-tested, with explicit corrections for multiple testing and overfitting.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

His methods are technically demanding and assume resources and data that many practitioners lack.

ENDURING IMPACT

His work is a leading reference for the rigorous application of machine learning in investment management.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 6)

Harry Markowitz · Giant 24
Fischer Black & Robert Litterman · Giant 25
Eugene Fama & Kenneth French · Giant 26
Agrawal, Gans & Goldfarb · Giant 28

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

López de Prado, M. (2018) Advances in Financial Machine Learning. Hoboken: Wiley.
Bailey, D.H. et al. (2014) 'Pseudo-mathematics and financial charlatanism', Notices of the AMS, 61(5).

Agrawal, Gans & Goldfarb

Economists of AI · prediction machines

Contemporary · Ajay Agrawal, Joshua Gans and Avi Goldfarb, University of Toronto.

> *"AI lowers the cost of prediction."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

They sought a clear economic account of what AI does, concluding that it is fundamentally a drop in the cost of prediction — not of judgment.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Economists at the Rotman School, they reframed AI through the lens of price theory: when the cost of prediction falls, demand for it and for its complements shifts.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

They anchor the Prediction Machines Lens in Unit 6's prediction-and-risk Slibrary, and inform the prediction-judgment split across the course.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Their framing operationalises as identifying where cheaper prediction creates value and where human judgment must still be supplied.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Treating AI purely as prediction can understate generative and agentic capabilities that blur the prediction-judgment line.

ENDURING IMPACT

Prediction Machines became a standard economic framing of AI for business and policy audiences.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 6)

Harry Markowitz · Giant 24
Fischer Black & Robert Litterman · Giant 25
Eugene Fama & Kenneth French · Giant 26
Marcos López de Prado · Giant 27

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Agrawal, A., Gans, J. and Goldfarb, A. (2018) Prediction Machines. Boston: HBR Press.
Agrawal, A., Gans, J. and Goldfarb, A. (2022) Power and Prediction. Boston: HBR Press.

RH

Reid Hoffman

Entrepreneur and investor · blitzscaling

GIANT 29 / 32
Unit 7

b. 1967 · co-founder of LinkedIn, partner at Greylock.

> *"Prioritise speed over efficiency to win."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Hoffman asked how companies win markets with winner-takes-most dynamics, concluding that under certain conditions speed should be prioritised over efficiency.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

From founding LinkedIn and investing across Silicon Valley, he codified the practice of rapid scaling in the face of uncertainty.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Blitzscaling Lens in Unit 7's scaling Slibrary.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Blitzscaling operationalises as deliberately accepting inefficiency and risk to capture a market before rivals, when network effects or first-scaler advantages apply.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Blitzscaling is risky and context-dependent; applied where its conditions do not hold, it produces fragile, cash-burning companies.

ENDURING IMPACT

Blitzscaling named and popularised a distinctive Silicon Valley scaling strategy, widely debated among founders and investors.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 7)

Peter Thiel · Giant 18 | **Geoffrey Moore** · Giant 30 | **Sangeet Choudary** · Giant 31 | **Sara Blakely** · Giant 32

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Hoffman, R. and Yeh, C. (2018) Blitzscaling. New York: Currency.

Sullivan, T. (2016) 'Blitzscaling', Harvard Business Review, 94(4).

GM

Geoffrey Moore

Technology-marketing theorist · Crossing the Chasm

GIANT 30 / 32
Unit 7

b. 1946 · American organisational theorist and management consultant.

> *"Win the beachhead before the mainstream."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Moore explained why many promising technology products stall: there is a 'chasm' between early adopters and the mainstream market that most fail to cross.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Building on the diffusion-of-innovations model, he focused on the discontinuity in the adoption curve and how to bridge it through a beachhead strategy.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the chasm-and-beachhead reasoning behind Unit 7's wedge-to-platform and vertical-versus-platform Slibraries.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His strategy operationalises as winning a narrow, well-defined beachhead segment completely before expanding to the mainstream.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The model is tailored to discontinuous technology products and fits less neatly where adoption is more continuous.

ENDURING IMPACT

Crossing the Chasm became essential reading for technology marketing and go-to-market strategy.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 7)

Peter Thiel · Giant 18 | **Reid Hoffman** · Giant 29 | **Sangeet Choudary** · Giant 31 | **Sara Blakely** · Giant 32

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Moore, G. (1991) Crossing the Chasm. New York: HarperBusiness.

Moore, G. (2014) Crossing the Chasm. 3rd edn. New York: HarperBusiness.

SC

Sangeet Choudary

Platform strategist · platform revolution

GIANT 31 / 32
Unit 7

Contemporary · author and adviser on platform business models.

> *"Platforms beat pipes."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Choudary asked why platform businesses outcompete traditional linear firms, concluding that orchestrating value created by others beats producing it yourself.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

His research on multi-sided platforms, with Parker and Van Alstyne, articulated the rules by which platforms create and capture value through network effects.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Platform-vs-Pipe distinction and the Network Effects Map in Unit 7's vertical-versus-platform and growth Slibraries.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His work operationalises as designing for ecosystem orchestration, governance and network effects rather than linear production.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Platform strategy is hard to execute and prone to winner-takes-most concentration and governance failures.

ENDURING IMPACT

Platform Revolution helped define the modern understanding of platform businesses that dominate the digital economy.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 7)

Peter Thiel · Giant 18 | **Reid Hoffman** · Giant 29 | **Geoffrey Moore** · Giant 30 | **Sara Blakely** · Giant 32

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Parker, G., Van Alstyne, M. and Choudary, S.P. (2016) Platform Revolution. New York: Norton.

Van Alstyne, M., Parker, G. and Choudary, S.P. (2016) 'Pipelines, platforms, and the new rules of strategy', Harvard Business Review, 94(4).

Sara Blakely

Entrepreneur · resilient building and bootstrapped growth

SB

b. 1971 · American entrepreneur, founder of Spanx.

> *"Failure is the best classroom."*

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Blakely's career embodies the conviction that resilience and a willingness to fail — not perfect resources — build durable companies.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

She built Spanx from a small personal investment into a major brand without outside funding, learning through repeated failure and persistence.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

She anchors the resilient-builder perspective in Unit 7's scaling Slibraries — a counterweight to pure speed-and-capital strategies.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Her example operationalises as treating failure as a classroom, building grit deliberately, and not letting the absence of resources excuse inaction.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Individual-founder lessons generalise imperfectly, and survivorship bias attends any single success story.

ENDURING IMPACT

Blakely became a prominent example of bootstrapped, resilient entrepreneurship and a widely cited founder voice.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 7)

Peter Thiel · Giant 18 | **Reid Hoffman** · Giant 29 | **Geoffrey Moore** · Giant 30 | **Sangeet Choudary** · Giant 31

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Blakely, S. (2021) interviews and public talks on building Spanx.

Bhide, A. (2000) The Origin and Evolution of New Businesses. Oxford: OUP.